

My rule for this season

A trellis, not a cage. Three core lines, and at most two optional ones. Write the rule you can keep in a difficult ordinary week. Private: you decide what anyone else sees.

Date:

Core

Regular ceasing and rest:

The first thing I will stop doing to protect it:

Prayer and Scripture (a fixed time):

One limit that protects my health or calling:

Optional (leave blank unless the retreat pointed here)

One relationship I will tend:

Additional commitment:

When I miss something: I will resume at the next appropriate opportunity without punishment, compensation, or guilt.

Two-week check:

Three-month review:

Person I will share this with (optional):

Read it to God. Then ask: is anything here already a cage rather than a trellis? Cross it out.

Unimpressive rules get kept

Regular ceasing and rest: Saturday noon to evening; no paid work or email; eat with family and walk. Phone stays outside the bedroom.

Prayer and Scripture: a psalm and five minutes of prayer at 7:00 a.m., Monday to Friday.

One limit: laptop closed by 7:00 p.m.

When I miss something: I will resume at the next appropriate opportunity without punishment, compensation, or guilt.

Two-week check: a date. **Three-month review:** a date. **Sharing with:** a named person.

"Without compensation": no double Sabbath to make up for a missed one, no hour of penitential prayer for a missed morning. Resume.

Two cautions

Write the rule you can keep in a difficult ordinary week, not the one you wish you had the capacity for. And if you share a life, do not write it alone: a Sabbath your household does not know about will collide with theirs.

Sabbath is not neglect

Necessary care, acts of mercy, emergencies and responsibilities that genuinely cannot be postponed may remain. Sunday a working day? Protect another regular period for rest. A caregiver? Safe respite is not selfish; if none is available, Sabbath fragments count. A full day impossible? Start with a half-day.

The three-month review, with your Eli

1. What have I kept?

2. What have I dropped, and why?

3. What has changed in my life that the rule needs to reflect?

4. What one thing would I add or remove?

Then rewrite the page with the new date. At two weeks, a lighter check: is this livable? If it already feels like a cage, remove something now.